

Mumbai–Ahmedabad Bullet Train Project

Concise Summary of the Provided Financial Times Report

Executive Summary

India's Mumbai–Ahmedabad high-speed rail project, developed with Japanese assistance, has faced major delays, rising costs and disagreements over procurement and technology. The 508-kilometre project was originally agreed in 2015 as a flagship example of India–Japan infrastructure cooperation, but it has yet to carry passengers. The dispute has highlighted different priorities on cost, technology localisation, procurement flexibility and project timelines.

Key Facts

Item	Summary
Route	Mumbai–Ahmedabad, approximately 508 km
Original agreement	2015 India–Japan agreement
Original estimated cost	About Rs980 billion
Japanese financing	50-year loan at 0.1% interest
Current estimated cost	At least Rs1.87 trillion
Original target	Operations targeted for 2023
Latest construction target	First section expected around early 2027
Planned wider network	Seven high-speed corridors covering nearly 4,000 km

Main Reasons for Delay and Disagreement

- **Land acquisition:** lengthy procedures significantly delayed the project after the original 2023 operational target.
- **Rising costs:** the estimated project cost has increased substantially from the original agreement.
- **Procurement dispute:** Japan has objected to India awarding a major signalling-related contract to Siemens, arguing that an integrated Japanese system would better preserve the safety and reliability associated with its bullet trains.
- **Technology localisation:** India wants greater domestic capability, flexibility and manufacturing under its broader 'Make in India' objectives.
- **Different project priorities:** Japanese stakeholders have emphasised an integrated technology package, while Indian negotiators have sought lower costs and greater future flexibility.
- **Cultural and management differences:** the report describes contrasting approaches to target-setting, implementation speed and attitudes toward delays.

Current Situation

India has indicated that limited high-speed operations could begin on part of the route, but the exact initial section and timing remain disputed. The report notes that India may use Indian-built trains for an early limited service, while Japanese next-generation E10 trains are not expected until the early 2030s. This

creates a potential gap between the completion of initial infrastructure and the availability of Japan's newest rolling stock.

Strategic Importance

The project is more than a transport initiative. For India, it is connected to the modernisation of the railway system, domestic technology manufacturing and the 'Make in India' programme. For Japan, the project represents an important infrastructure partnership and an opportunity to export its high-speed rail technology. Both countries also have a strategic interest in maintaining close relations as China becomes increasingly assertive in the region.

Future Outlook

Despite the disagreements, both governments continue to describe the broader relationship as important. India plans to develop several additional high-speed rail corridors and expects large-scale investment in the sector. The success of the Mumbai–Ahmedabad project will therefore influence not only the first bullet train in India but also future decisions about technology, procurement, financing and international partnerships in Indian high-speed rail.

Conclusion

The Mumbai–Ahmedabad bullet train project demonstrates both the opportunities and difficulties of large international infrastructure projects. Japan provides advanced high-speed rail expertise and favourable financing, while India seeks to control costs, develop domestic capabilities and retain greater technological flexibility. Resolving procurement and implementation disagreements will be critical to delivering the project and maintaining confidence in future India–Japan rail cooperation.

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